# How Made for you chooses

A listener's taste profile and the ranking built on it, generated from FAM's code.

ALGO_VERSION 2026-10-05.1 · fingerprint c528f925841f209f · regenerate with `python tools/algorithm_docs.py`

## What Made for you is

The first rail on myFAM, chosen for one listener from two inventories: today's live stories and the evergreen bank.

- Built on every page load, never stored - a pure query over the listener's own event log.
- Trending chooses first, from the world, and Made for you never shows what Trending holds.
- Nothing on the page generates an episode: tiles are a title and an angle, written on tap.

## 1. The taste profile

Every action is logged with the subjects of what it was about. Each kind of action has a weight.

- A signal halves every 14 days.
- Behaviour is scaled so the strongest subject is 1.0.
- Chosen interests are then added at 2, constant: never decayed, never outvoted, never lowered by a skip. They are the part a listener controls on purpose.
- Impressions (a tile being shown) are never taste.

| Signal | Weight | What it is |
|---|---|---|
| vibe | 2.5 | VIBE! on an episode |
| pick | 2.2 | A subject picked from a list (the interests page) |
| mix_add | 2 | A subject or episode added to one of your mixes |
| share | 2 | Sending an episode to someone |
| save | 2 | Save for later |
| search | 1.5 | Typing (or saying) a question |
| complete | 1.5 | Finishing an episode (85% heard) |
| play | 1 | Starting an episode |
| skip | -0.5 | Skipping an episode |
| not_interested | -1.5 | Not interested, from a tile's three dots - the tile also leaves your rails |

## 2. A tree, not a list

Subjects live in a category tree with no depth limit: sport > American football > NFL > Bengals.

- The most specific subject an episode is about takes the whole signal.
- Each heading above it takes 0.6x per level (0.6, 0.36, 0.216 ...).
- So a Bengals fan's profile knows the Bengals best, and the NFL and football as a whole too.
- The tree grows from what listeners search; most major-league teams are seeded so one fan's team counts from day one.

## 3. Scoring a tile

affinity = sum over the tile's tags of (taste x specificity), divided by the square root of the number of tags.

- Specificity: a heading 1.0, a subtag 1.75, a category 1.75 to the power of its depth - so a story on the specific subject beats one on its heading.
- Plus a meaning match (embeddings) where the model is installed.
- x fatigue, x freshness (1 + 1.6 x push, live only), x local 1.5, x engagement (0.6-1.5).
- Kept only above 0.12.

## 4. What is never offered

Exclusions, applied before or instead of a score.

- Anything the listener has already heard (a moved-on live story comes back as a 'what's new' follow-up).
- A live story that names nothing they follow - only the heading matches, no word they used, no near paraphrase.
- A minor-league game on another continent, unless they follow the team or league.
- Anything Trending or 'What you missed' already holds.

## 5. Shaping the rail

After scoring, the rail is arranged, not re-ranked.

- Already-written episodes go first, 24 deep.
- At most 2 tiles per heading - strictly.
- Topped up to 4 from evergreen tiles by affinity - never from the live pool.
- A learned re-ranker may reorder what cleared the floor, only if one has been trained and beat the hand order.

## 6. A brand-new listener

With no actions and no interests, the profile is a prior.

- Headings ranked by what everyone plays, each 0.08 lower than the one above.
- The startup questions lead, a local one first if they gave a town.
- One play, search or chosen interest replaces the prior for good.

## Worked example: a Bengals fan

Run through the real `taste` and `_affinity` over the seeded category tree.

| Action | Text | Days ago | Weight | After decay |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| complete | cincinnati bengals injury report | 0.5 | 1.5 | 1.463 |
| complete | how the bengals rebuilt their offensive line | 2 | 1.5 | 1.359 |
| complete | bengals playoff chances this season | 4 | 1.5 | 1.231 |
| search | bengals quarterback contract | 1 | 1.5 | 1.428 |
| search | nfl trade deadline winners | 3 | 1.5 | 1.293 |
| play | how do mrna vaccines work | 6 | 1 | 0.743 |
| skip | college football playoff rankings explained | 2 | -0.5 | -0.453 |

Chosen interest: **culture** - held constant on top of everything else.

Their profile, as the tree it is:

```
Culture  2.00
Sport  0.41
    American Football  0.45
        NFL  0.84
            Bengals  1.00
    Sports Business  0.26
    Sports Drama  0.24
    Trade Deadline  0.24
Health & mind  0.05
    Medicine  0.08
        Vaccines  0.14
```

How six tiles score (affinity, before the multipliers):

| Tile | Tags it carries | Affinity |
|---|---|---|
| Bengals injury report before Sunday | american football, bengals, nfl, sports | 4.559 |
| NFL trade deadline: who won | american football, nfl, sports, trade deadline | 2.086 |
| Inside the Oscars race | culture | 2 |
| College football playoff picture | american football, college football, football, sports | 0.401 |
| Premier League title race | football, premier league, sports | 0.152 |

| Tile | Tags it carries | Affinity |
|---|---|---|
| A new malaria vaccine | health, science | 0.035 |

## What changed

**2026-10-05.1** (§202)

- Taste is a subject tree: the most specific subject an episode is about takes the whole signal, each heading above it 0.6x per level (Bengals > NFL > American football > sport).
- Chosen interests are constant: added after normalisation at 2, never decayed, never outvoted, never taken below that by a skip. Named subjects from the interests page count as well as the eight facets.
- Weights: search 2 -> 1.5, finish 2 -> 1.5, pick 1.6 -> 2.2.
- New signal: adding something to a mix (mix_add) is worth 2.0.
- Most NFL, NBA, MLB and NHL teams are seeded into the category tree under their leagues, so one fan's team is a subject from their first search. A team whose name is also weather or the news ('Carolina Hurricanes') is left to grow from real sports questions.

**2026-09-23.3** (§187)

- Owner's weights: search 2, play 1, finish 2, skip -0.5, save 2, vibe 2.5. Made for you files subjects by field; variety cap is strict; no far minor leagues; market moves on any money taste.

## Every constant

| Name | Value | Meaning |
|---|---|---|
| HALF_LIFE | 1209600 | Seconds for a signal to lose half its weight |
| INTEREST_WEIGHT | 2 | A chosen interest, constant, after normalisation |
| ANCESTOR_SHARE | 0.6 | Share of a signal each heading above a subject gets, per level |
| SUBTAG_WEIGHT | 1.75 | How much a subtag match counts next to a facet match |
| CATEGORY_DEPTH_WEIGHT | 1.75 | Per-level specificity of a grown category (compounds) |
| FRESHNESS_BOOST | 1.6 | Live story lift: 1 + this x freshness |
| LOCAL_BOOST | 1.5 | Live story naming the listener's city or region |
| BROAD_MATCH_PENALTY | 0 | Live story with no sign of interest (0 = excluded) |
| SEMANTIC_NEAR_COSINE | 0.6 | Similarity that counts as 'been near' a subject |
| SUBJECT_DEPTH | 2 | Tree depth at which a category names a subject |
| RELEVANCE_FLOOR | 0.12 | Below this a tile is not a recommendation |
| FATIGUE_WEIGHT | 0.35 | Damping per ignored showing |
| FATIGUE_GRACE | 2 | Showings before fatigue counts |
| FATIGUE_FLOOR | 0.15 | Fatigue never pushes below this |
| ENGAGEMENT_WEIGHT | 1 | Strength of the global tap-rate term |
| ENGAGEMENT_PRIOR | 20 | Showings before a tile's own tap rate counts |
| ENGAGEMENT_FLOOR | 0.6 | Lowest engagement multiplier |
| ENGAGEMENT_CEILING | 1.5 | Highest engagement multiplier |
| SECTION_SIZE | 4 | Tiles on a rail |
| MAX_PER_FACET | 2 | Most tiles from one heading on Made for you |
| CANDIDATE_FACTOR | 3 | Candidates per shown tile handed to the variety pass |
| READY_REACH | 24 | How deep the rail looks for already-written episodes |
| STARTUP_PRIOR_STEP | 0.08 | Cold start: drop per rank of a heading's popularity |